The Trestle at Pope Lick Creek

By Naomi Wallace

DALTON: You had a head start!

PACE: Nah. You haven't got any lungs in that puny chest of yours.

DALTON: So, this is it, huh? *(They look above them)*

PACE: Yep.

DALTON: It's not that high up.

PACE: Almost a hundred feet. From the creek up.

DALTON: Some creek. There's no water: it's dry.

PACE: Don't care; can't swim anyway. What time is it?

DALTON: Coming up to seven.

PACE: She usually comes through at seven ten; but she's never exact. You can't trust her. That's what I like.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *It's 1936 . . . High atop a railroad trestle that spans a bone dry creek, two teenagers (Pace and Dalton) plan to race across the bridge against an oncoming locomotive.*

ACTOR: *At first their scheme adds excitement to their lives in a small factory town during the Great Depression but . . .*

ACTRESS: *This isn't Pace's first time racing the train . . . . she's done it before and her partner in crime that time (Brett) didn't make it*

ACTOR: *How far would you go to feel alive in a time frame and in a town where everything appears to be dying? Would you be willing to try to outrun the Great Depression?*

TOGETHER: *The Trestle at Pope Lick Creek by Naomi Wallace*

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DALTON: How many times have you done it?

PACE: Once. And that's once more than you. It'll be just you and me. Up there. And

you can be sure we'll check our pants when we're done and see who's shit.

DALTON: You know. You don't talk like a girl should.

PACE: *(meaning it)* Thanks. Listen. She's pulling eight cars at seventy tons a piece at eighty five. The engine herself is one hundred and fifty three tons. Just cold, lip-smackin' steel. Imagine a kiss like that.

DALTON: How to you know what the train weighs?

PACE: I looked it up. The year, the weight, the speed.

DALTON: So, you can read.

PACE: Yeah, well. You and her are coming from opposite sides, right. You've got to time it exact 'cause you need to make it across before she hits the trestle. Just face her and go.

DALTON: So what if you know it's too close? You go for the side, right?

PACE: There's no side.

DALTON: So what do you do if you can't make it across before she starts over?

PACE; You make it across – that's all there is to it.

DALTON; But what if you can't?

PACE: Remember Brett Weaver?

DALTON: That's different. He was drunk.

PACE: Say it again and I'll punch you. Brett wasn't drunk. He was just slow.

DALTON: Well. I've decided: I'm not crossing.

PACE: I knew it.

DALTON: Only a drunk or an idiot would play that game. Not me.

PACE: You got the heart of a rabbit – a dead rabbit.

DALTON: No way. I never said for certain. I said maybe. And you said it was safe. You didn't say anything about there being no safety sides. You said it was a piece of cake.

PACE: It is a piece of cake.

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DALTON: Forget it.

PACE: You're breaking the deal. Pay me a buck right now or else.

DALTON: I said no.

PACE: Then why'd you come up here with me? If you back down, everyone will know.

DALTON: So how close were you that time you crossed?

PACE: I'd say I had 'bout eight seconds leeway. It will be a snap (snaps fingers)

DALTON: What if you trip?

PACE: You're going to run the trestle. 'Cause if you don't, your life will turn out just like you think it will: quick, dirty and cold. Come on. Let's go up. Let's make something happen. *(transition, change of positions)*

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PACE: Now repeat after me: We don't want to die.

DALTON: We don't want to die.

PACE: Tell you what. We'll have a practice first. Let's start here. See, this tie's marked with a red X. Now, you crouch down like this. But don't check your feet. You'll trip if you check your feet. If you start when I tell you to, you'll have enough time to make it across. Ready?

DALTON: Pace?

PACE: Yeah?

DALTON: My legs are shaking.

PACE: This is practice, Dalton. There's no train.

DALTON: My legs aren't so sure.

PACE: On the count of trhee. Come on.

TOGETHER: One . . . two . . . three . . .

DALTON: Wait! *(He seems to be looking over an edge)*

PAGE: Don't look. You'll lose your nerve.

DALTON: It's a long way down.

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PAGE: Why don't we just walk it? Give me your hand. *(She takes his hand and begins to walk.).*

DALTON: Gosh, we're high up.

PACE: Keep your eyes on the other side. We're almost there. And now you trip. *(Pace trips him so he falls)*

DALTON: Hey! What the . . . you tripped me . . .

PACE: It might happen. You might trip. Anything's possible. We got to be ready for it.

DALTON: But I wouldn't have tripped! You pushed me.

PACE: Let's say you look over your shoulder to see how I'm doing and you do. And you can hear her cold, slathering, black, hell of a heart barreling towards the trestle. But you've twisted your ankle.

DALTON: Yeah. And I can hardly stand. And the train, she's just about to cross.

PACE: And then there I am. At your side.

DALTON: No. You've got to save your own skin.

PACE: Yeah, but I can't just leave you there.

DALTON: Yes, you can. I'll be torn apart.

PACE: So I put my arm around your waist and start to drag you down the tracks with me. We've only got fifty feet or so.

DALTON: But the train – so you drop me.

PACE: No!

DALTON: You drop me and run. You run for your life.

PACE: No. I don't leave you. I . . .

DALTON: You make it across. Just in time. Alone.

PACE: I drag you with me.

DALTON: And as you clear the tracks, you feel the wind as she rushes by you. And then – you hear me scream *(he screams – at the same time, Pace screams the*

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following).

PACE: I SAVE YOU! *(silence for some moments)*

DALTON: And then?

PACE: I'm alive. Alive!

DALTON: As for me, well, I'm dead. But still you have to go back and have a look. To see what's left. Of course there's almost nothing left.

PACE: Yeah, there was. There was a lot left.

DALTON: No, just some bits of meat and a running show. That's all.

PACE: He wasn't wearing running shoes.

DALTON: And now maybe my Mom will be able to scrounge up some new shoes for the funeral. If she can find my feet.

PACE: Just shut up. You are wrong. That's not what a train does to you. It doesn't mush you up. This train. She's a knife. We had a good start. Me and Brett. We could have made it. 'Course Brett was faster. I expected to be running behind, but Brett was worried – about me. He turned to look over his shoulder at me and he tripped. I thought he'd just jump up and keep going, so I passed him right by. *(beat)* I thought Brett was right behind me.

DALTON: You left him on the tracks?

PACE: I thought he was running behind me. I could hear him behind me. He didn't call out. He didn't say wait up. I didn't know. Why didn't he call out? Not even a sound. Brett just sat there where he'd fallen. And then he stood up. He stood there, looking her straight in the face – almost like it was a dare. Like: Go ahead and hit me. You can't do that to a train. You can't dare a train to hit you – cause it will.

DALTON: This is stupid.

PACE: Just stood there like she could pass right through him for all he cared.

DALTON: Let's get out of here, it's getting late *(tries to take her arm)*

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PACE: *(she pulls away)* Let go of me.

DALTON: You're out of your mind. *(climbs back down to the creek bed)*

PACE: *(calls after him)* It's not how you think it is. The train, she doesn't mush you up. I walked down the tracks after the train passed. She cut Brett in two.

DALTON: Pace.

PACE: You know what I thought? Blocks. Two blocks and maybe if I could fit the pieces back together again, he'd be . . . whole.

DALTON: Will you shut your mouth. Please.

PACE: We're going to do it for real.

DALTON: Yeah. *(to placate her . . . still climbing down)*

PACE: Both of us. Side by side.

DALTON: That's right. *(sarcastic)*

PACE: A steady run. *(hears the train and starts across the trestle)*

DALTON: Where are you going? Pace. Hey, Pace.

PACE: I'm going to make something happen. *(she turns her back audience- out of scene)*

DALTON: *(to audience)* She stood on the tracks. I stood below the trestle. She looked small up there . . . But until she started to run, I never thought she'd do it without me. *(to Pace)* No! Stop. You better stop! *(to audience)* Pace must've slowed down and lost her speed when she was calling to me. She started to run back, but she knew she'd never make it. And then she turned. Even from where I was, I could see she was shaking her head. Back and forth, like she was saying: No. No. No *(pause)* She didn't want to die. And then she did something funny. Pace couldn't even swim, and there was no water in the creek, but she was going to dive.

PACE: Watch me, Dalton *(turn)*

DALTON: And this time. I watched her *(pause)* Pace lay beside the trestle. I started to shout at her, but she was dead. *(pause)* Well, Pace, you made something

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happen. I have to believe that.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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